

UNIT 4: LIFE ISSUES

Chapter 27: 3. If..., a poem by Kipling

Ce livret d'excellence tout-en-un est spécialement conçu pour offrir aux élèves de 4ème Année Secondaire en Tunisie une préparation d'élite à l'épreuve d'Anglais du Baccalauréat. Il réunit l'analyse littéraire exhaustive du poème mythique 'If' de Rudyard Kipling, le portefeuille lexical d'examen, la maîtrise absolue de la grammaire (Inversion poétique avec '**Nor**' et structures conditionnelles), ainsi qu'un recueil de 40 questions-réponses clés pour la révision active.

Discipline / Section	Anglais - Toutes Sections (Tronc Commun & Option Lettres)
Syllabus Officiel	Tunisian Ministry of Education - Textbook: Skills for Life
Unit / Chapter Focus	Unit 4: Life Issues Chapter 27 (Lesson 3): 'If...' by Rudyard Kipling
Target Grade	20/20 au Baccalauréat (Fiche de Prestige)

PART 1: THE EXHAUSTIVE COURSE THEORY

1. Biographical & Literary Context

Rudyard Kipling (1865 - 1936) was born in Bombay, India, but educated in England. In 1882, he returned to India where he worked for Anglo-Indian newspapers. He was chiefly known as a highly prolific writer of short stories and achieved rapid international fame. He is celebrated for classics such as *The Jungle Book* (1894), *The Second Jungle Book* (1895), *Captains Courageous* (1897), and *Just So Stories* (1902). In 1907, Kipling made history by becoming the first English-language writer to be awarded the **Nobel Prize in Literature**.

His iconic poem '**If...**' (originally written in 1895 and collected in 1910) serves as an address from a father to his son, laying down the ultimate **Victorian Stoic Code of Conduct**. The poem is structured as a single massive conditional sentence where a sequence of life situations is introduced, culminating in the final reward of maturity, self-mastery, and true manhood.

2. Official Textbook Poem Extract

IF by Rudyard Kipling (Syllabus Excerpt):

If you can keep your head when all about you
Are losing theirs and blaming it on you;
If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you,
But make allowance for their doubting too;
If you can wait and not be tired by waiting,
Or, being lied about, don't deal in lies,
Or being hated don't give way to hating,
And yet don't look too good, nor talk too wise;
If you can dream---and not make dreams your master;
If you can think---and not make thoughts your aim,
If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster
And treat those two impostors just the same.
[...]
If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue,
Or walk with Kings---nor lose the common touch,
If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you,
If all men count with you, but none too much:
If you can fill the unforgiving minute
With sixty seconds' worth of distance run,
Yours is the Earth and everything that's in it,

And---which is more---you'll be a Man, my son!

Themes & Rhetorical Analysis:

- **Personification of Triumph & Disaster:** Kipling refers to Triumph and Disaster as '**two impostors**' because they represent extreme, fleeting emotional states that deceive men. Believing too much in success (Triumph) breeds arrogance, while falling prey to failure (Disaster) breeds despair. The Stoic must treat both with the same emotional detachment.
- **The Unforgiving Minute:** Time is personified as 'unforgiving' because once spent, it can never be retrieved. The poet urges the reader to fill every single minute with 'sixty seconds' worth of distance run', symbolizing intense, constructive effort and purposeful action.

3. Character Pillars Visual Breakdown

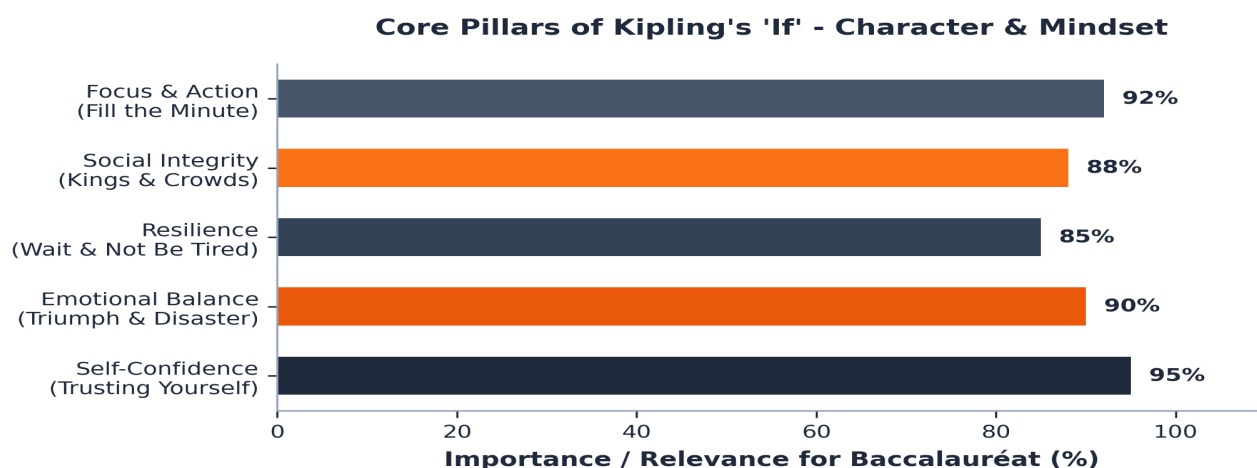


Figure 1.1: Core Stoic Pillars of Kipling's 'If' prioritized for Bac Exam analysis.

4. Core Lexical Portfolio

Vocabulary	IPA Phonetics	Synonyms & Meanings	Bac Exam Context / Example
Triumph	/ˈtraɪ.ʌmf/	Victory, supreme success, conquest. (Antonym: Disaster)	A Stoic meets with Triumph and Disaster with equal poise.
Foes	/fəʊz/	Enemies, adversaries, opponents. (Antonym: Friends)	If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you, you are resilient.
Virtue	/ˈvɜː.tʃuː/	Moral excellence, goodness, high values. (Antonym: Vice)	You must talk with crowds and keep your virtue unstained.
Impostor	/ɪmˈpɒs.tər/	Deceiver, fraud, person who pretends.	He treats both Triumph and Disaster as deceptive impostors .
Give way to	/ɡɪv weɪ tuː/	Stop resisting, yield, surrender.	Despite being hated, do not give way to hating others.
Make allowance	/meɪk əˈləʊ.əns/	Take into consideration, excuse, tolerate.	Trust yourself but make allowance for other people's doubts.
Loathe	/ləʊð/	Hate intensely, detest, despise.	Do not loathe or look down upon those who disagree with you.
Common touch	/ˈkɒm.ən tʌtʃ/	Ability to relate to ordinary, common people.	Even when walking with Kings, never lose the common touch .

5. Grammar Mastery: Inversion with 'Nor' & Conditionals

A. Inversion with 'NOR':

In the line: 'Or walk with Kings---nor lose the common touch', Kipling uses a classic literary inversion. In English grammar, when a sentence begins with a negative adverb or conjunction like '**Nor**', **Subject-Verb Inversion** must take place. The auxiliary verb comes before the subject.

- **Formula: Nor + Auxiliary Verb (do/does/did/can/will) + Subject + Base Verb**
- Standard: He does not lie, and he does not cheat.
- Inverted: He does not lie, **nor does he cheat**.
- Bac Transformation Example: They cannot afford education. They cannot find clean water.
→ They cannot afford education, **nor can they find** clean water.

B. Conditional Structures (Type 1 & Type 2):

- **Conditional Type 1 (Real/Probable Present-Future): If + Simple Present → Will + Base Verb (or Imperative / Modal).**

Kipling's whole poem is a Conditional Type 1: 'If you can fill the unforgiving minute... [then] yours is the Earth.'

- **Conditional Type 2 (Imaginary/Hypothetical): If + Simple Past → Would + Base Verb.**

Example from textbook: 'If people were less consumerist, they would protect the Earth.'

6. Phonetics: Silent Letters & Vowel Discrimination

A. Silent Letters in Chapter 27:

Silent letters are letters that are written but not pronounced. These are a primary target of Bac discrimination questions:

- **Doubt** → The letter '**b**' is silent: /daʊt/.
- **Knives** → The letter '**k**' is silent: /neɪvz/.
- **Thoughts** → The letters '**gh**' are silent: /θɔ:ts/.
- **Write** → The letter '**w**' is silent: /raɪt/.

B. Vowel Contrast & Phonetic Discrimination (Minimal Pairs):

Word A	Phonetics (A)	Word B	Phonetics (B)	Acoustic / Articulatory Contrast
breathe	/bri:ð/ (verb)	breath	/breθ/ (noun)	Contrast between long vowel /i:/ and short vowel /e/.
touch	/tʌtʃ/	nothing	/'nʌθ.ɪŋ/	Both share the identical short central vowel sound /ʌ/.
minute	/'mɪn.ɪt/	risk	/rɪsk/	Both share the identical short front vowel sound /ɪ/.
lose	/lu:z/	fools	/fu:lz/	Both share the identical long back rounded vowel sound /u:/.
foes	/fəʊz/	broken	/'brəʊ.kən/	Both share the identical centering diphthong sound /əʊ/.
son	/sʌn/	gone	/gɒn/	Contrast between short central /ʌ/ and short open back /ɒ/.

7. Model Creative Task: The Student's 'IF' Poem

An 8-line poem in the style of Kipling tailored for the Baccalauréat Writing Task:

If you can wake at dawn and face your fear,
 When lazy thoughts and doubts are calling near;
 If you can read with focus through the night,
 And keep your golden goals in constant sight;
 If you can fail a test but stand up tall,
 And find the strength to rise above the fall;
 Then success is yours, the future is won,
 And you will reach your dreams, my noble son!

PART 2: THE ACTIVE RECALL REPOSITORY

Hide the right column to test your knowledge dynamically.

Bac Question / Active Recall Focus	Model Answer / Grammar & Key Explanations
Who is the author of 'If'?	Rudyard Kipling (1865-1936), born in Bombay and the first English-language writer to win the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1907.
What is the central theme of 'If'?	The poem outlines a stoic philosophy of life, advocating for self-discipline, resilience, emotional balance, humility, and determination.
To whom is the poem 'If' addressed?	The poem is addressed by a father to his son, passing down wisdom on how to become a mature, virtuous man.
How is the poem 'If' grammatically structured?	It is structured as a series of Conditional Type 1 clauses ('If you can...') leading to a single ultimate consequence in the final two lines.
What does the expression 'keep your head' mean?	It means to remain calm, sensible, and rational in a difficult, chaotic, or stressful situation.
What bad attitude is highlighted in the very first stanza?	Losing composure ('losing their head') under pressure and falsely blaming others for one's own failures.
Why does the poet advise making allowance for other's doubts?	To balance self-confidence with humility; one must believe in oneself but understand and respect why others might doubt.
What does 'don't deal in lies' imply?	It means maintaining absolute moral integrity and honesty, never reciprocating deceit even when lied about by others.
Explain: 'don't look too good, nor talk too wise'.	It warns against vanity, self-righteousness, and intellectual snobbery. Do not boast of your own virtues or wisdom.
Why are 'Triumph' and 'Disaster' called 'two impostors'?	They are personified as impostors because both success and failure are temporary, misleading, and can distort a person's true character.
How should a wise man treat Triumph and Disaster?	With complete emotional detachment and equal poise ('treat those two impostors just the same').
What is the 'unforgiving minute' in the poem?	A personification of time as unforgiving because wasted time can never be retrieved or made up for.
Explain: 'sixty seconds' worth of distance run'.	It means utilizing every precious second of life with productive effort, hard work, and purposeful actions.
What are 'knaves' in the context of the poem?	Deceitful, dishonest, and unprincipled people who twist truths to trap and manipulate others.
What does the phrase 'keep your virtue' mean?	To retain your moral standards, integrity, and good character even when socializing with crowds or ordinary people.
What does 'lose the common touch' mean?	To become arrogant, aloof, or detached from ordinary, humble people after achieving success or walking with Kings.

Bac Question / Active Recall Focus	Model Answer / Grammar & Key Explanations
Explain the line: 'If all men count with you, but none too much'.	Value and respect every person equally, but do not depend excessively on anyone's approval or opinions.
What is the final reward promised in the poem?	If you fulfill these conditions, you will inherit the Earth and become a true, mature Man ('you'll be a Man, my son!').
What is a synonym of 'foes'?	'Enemies', 'adversaries', 'opponents'. It is the antonym of 'friends'.
What does 'triumph' mean?	A great victory, conquest, or spectacular success. It is the opposite of 'disaster'.
Define the word 'impostor'.	A person who deceives others by pretending to be someone else or representing something false.
What does 'give way to' mean?	To yield, surrender, or stop resisting (e.g., 'don't give way to hating' means don't surrender to hate).
What is 'virtue'?	Behavior showing high moral standards, goodness, and ethical excellence.
What is the antonym of 'virtue'?	'Vice' (moral weakness, bad behavior, or corruption).
What is a synonym of 'loathe'?	To hate intensely, detest, or despise. The opposite is to cherish or adore.
Identify the odd one out: trust - faith - belief - doubt - confidence.	Doubt. It is negative and expresses uncertainty, while the others express positive belief and confidence.
Identify the odd one out: wise - sensible - judicious - rational - unreasonable.	Unreasonable. It represents a lack of logic, whereas the others denote high intelligence and sanity.
Identify the odd one out: vice - morality - honour - honesty - virtue.	Vice. It represents bad behavior, while the others represent positive moral values.
Identify the odd one out: dislike - loathe - cherish - detest - hate.	Cherish. It means to love and protect, whereas the others mean to hate intensely.
State the formula for Subject-Verb Inversion with 'Nor'.	Nor + Auxiliary Verb (do/does/did/can/will) + Subject + Base Verb.
Transform: 'He doesn't waste energy. He doesn't pollute.' (using 'nor')	He doesn't waste energy, nor does he pollute.
Transform: 'They cannot afford food. They cannot find shelter.' (using 'nor')	They cannot afford food, nor can they find shelter.

Bac Question / Active Recall Focus	Model Answer / Grammar & Key Explanations
What tense is used in the 'if-clause' of Conditional Type 1?	The Simple Present tense (e.g., 'If you can fill ...').
What tense/structure is used in the main clause of Conditional Type 1?	The Simple Future (will + V), an imperative, or a present modal (e.g., 'Yours is the Earth').
What does 'Unless we help him, he will fail' become with 'If'?	If we do not help him, he will fail. (Unless = If + Not, avoiding double negatives).
Identify the silent letter in the word 'doubt'.	The letter ' b ' is completely silent: pronounced /daʊt/.
Identify the silent letter in the word 'knaves'.	The letter ' k ' is silent: pronounced /neɪvz/.
Identify the silent letters in the word 'thoughts'.	The letters ' gh ' are completely silent: pronounced /θɔ:ts/.
What is the phonological contrast between 'breathe' and 'breath'?	'Breathe' is a verb with a long vowel /i:/, whereas 'breath' is a noun with a short vowel /e/.
Are the vowel sounds in 'touch' and 'nothing' similar or different?	Similar. They both share the short central vowel sound /ʌ/.
Are the vowel sounds in 'lose' and 'fools' similar or different?	Similar. They both share the long back rounded vowel sound /u:/.

PART 3: EXAM EVALUATION QUIZ & SUMMARY MEMOS

1. Diagnostic Practice Quiz (10 Questions)

Test your preparation against these classic Bac exam questions. Answers are below.

Q1. Which of the following works was NOT written by Rudyard Kipling?

- a) The Jungle Book
- b) Captains Courageous
- c) The Daffodils
- d) Just So Stories

Q2. Why does Kipling describe Triumph and Disaster as 'impostors'?

- a) Because they are permanent and final.
- b) Because they are deceptive and temporary states of mind.
- c) Because they are both illegal activities.
- d) Because they only affect dishonest people.

Q3. Identify the correct Subject-Verb Inversion:

- a) He did not arrive on time, nor he did call us.
- b) He did not arrive on time, nor did he call us.
- c) He did not arrive on time, nor he called us.
- d) He did not arrive on time, nor did he called us.

Q4. Complete with the correct word: 'Trust yourself, but make ____ for other's doubts.'

- a) allowance
- b) deduction
- c) subtraction
- d) resistance

Q5. Choose the correct phonetic symbol for the vowel sound in 'touch':

- a) /æ/
- b) /ʌ/
- c) /ɒ/
- d) /i:/

Q6. (True/False) In a non-restrictive relative clause, the relative pronoun 'that' can replace 'which'.

Justification: _____

Q7. (True/False) The word 'doubt' contains a silent 't' letter.

Justification: _____

Q8. (True/False) 'Breathe' is a noun whereas 'breath' is a verb.

Justification: _____

Q9. (True/False) Kipling was the first English-language writer to win the Nobel Prize in Literature.

Justification: _____

Q10. (True/False) 'Unless you fill the minute, you will waste your life' means 'If you fill the minute, you will waste your life'.

Justification: _____

2. Pedagogical Correction & Explanations

Q1. Correct Answer: c) The Daffodils. The Daffodils is a poem by William Wordsworth (Unit 3, Chap 23). The other three are world-famous prose masterpieces written by Kipling.

Q2. Correct Answer: b) Because they are deceptive and temporary. Kipling calls them 'impostors' because success (Triumph) and failure (Disaster) are fleeting; they deceive people into arrogance or despair.

Q3. Correct Answer: b) ...nor did he call us.. The structure requires Nor + Auxiliary (did) + Subject (he) + Base Verb (call). Options 'c' and 'a' lack inversion, and 'd' uses a past tense verb 'called' instead of the base form.

Q4. Correct Answer: a) allowance. The idiomatic expression used in Kipling's poem is 'to make allowance for', which means to take into account or tolerate.

Q5. Correct Answer: b) /ʌ/. The vowel sound in 'touch' is the short central vowel ` /ʌ/ , identical to the vowel sound in 'nothing', 'son', and 'love'.

Q6. FALSE. In English grammar, the pronoun **'that'** can never be used in non-restrictive (non-defining) relative clauses (which are separated by commas). Only 'which' is permitted.

Q7. FALSE. The word 'doubt' contains a silent **'b'** letter (pronounced /daʊt/), not a silent 't'.

Q8. FALSE. It is exactly the opposite: 'breathe' (with an 'e' at the end) is the verb, and 'breath' (without an 'e') is the noun.

Q9. TRUE. Rudyard Kipling was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1907, making him the first English-language author to receive this prestigious honor.

Q10. FALSE. The word unless means if... not. Thus, the correct transformation is: **'If you do not fill the minute, you will waste your life.'** The provided statement is a contradiction.

3. Mémos d'Excellence (Summary Charts)

Tableau Memo 1.1: Visual Poetic & Rhetorical Devices Guide

Poetic Term	Definition / Meaning	Example from Chapter 27
Stanza	A group of lines of verse forming the basic unit of a poem.	Kipling's 'If' is composed of structured stanzas (the excerpt has 2 parts).
Rhyme	Identical end-of-word sounds that create musicality.	about you / doubt you (a) waiting / hating (b)
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds for emphasis.	'Walk with Kings---nor lose the common touch '.
Personification	Endowing inanimate objects / abstract concepts with human traits.	Triumph and Disaster are treated as 'two impostors' who can talk/deceive.
Simile	Direct comparison between two unlike things using 'like' or 'as'.	'I wandered lonely as a cloud' (Wordsworth, Unit 3).

Tableau Memo 1.2: Phonetic Guide to Silent Letters & Minimal Pairs

Phenomenon	Rule / Explanations	Core Examples to Memorize
Silent Letters	Letters that are written in spelling but must never be pronounced.	b in doubt k in knaves gh in thoughts w in write
Noun / Verb Pairs	Pronunciation changes (vowel length & final consonant) based on part of speech.	Verb: to breathe (/bri:ð/ - long vowel) Noun: a breath (/breθ/ - short vowel)
Identical Vowels	Words with completely different spelling sharing identical vowel sounds.	/ʌ/ sound: touch , nothing , son , love /u:/ sound: lose , fools , true